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THE INDIAN GIG & PLATFORM WORKER PLAYBOOK

2026-27 Edition

Your rights, registration, benefits, tax and money —
for India's delivery partners, cab drivers and home-service pros.

THE 2025-26 LAW · E-SHRAM STEP-BY-STEP · Rs 5 LAKH HEALTH COVER · ITR & TDS · YOUR RIGHTS

Every fact verified from the Ministry of Labour & Employment, e-Shram, PIB,
the Income Tax Department and PFRDA. Compiled October 2026.

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About this playbook

This is a practical guide to the biggest change in Indian labour law for app-based workers in a generation — and to the money questions that come with working for a platform instead of a company. It is written for delivery partners, cab and bike-taxi drivers, and home-service professionals on apps such as Zomato, Blinkit, Swiggy, Zepto, Uber, Ola, Rapido, Amazon, Porter and Urban Company — and for anyone thinking of starting gig work.

Everything here is drawn from primary, official sources: the Code on Social Security, 2020; the Social Security (Central) Rules, 2026; the Ministry of Labour & Employment; the e-Shram portal; PIB releases; Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha answers; the Income Tax Department; CBIC; PFRDA; and NITI Aayog. Where a number comes from a company — for example, how many delivery partners filed returns — it is labelled as the company's own disclosure. Where a benefit is announced but not yet fully operational, this playbook says so plainly instead of pretending it is live.

This is general information, not legal, tax or financial advice. Rules and scheme details change; always confirm the current position on the official portal — e-Shram (eshram.gov.in), the Income Tax e-filing portal, or your platform's partner app — before you act on something that matters to you.

How to use this playbook

Part 1 explains what the new law actually says. Part 2 gets you registered — it is free and it is your key to everything else. Part 3 covers the benefits you may already qualify for. Part 4 stops you overpaying tax and starts you claiming refunds. Part 5 is the one to photograph and keep on your phone. The 30-day action plan at the back turns all of it into a checklist you can finish in a month.

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PART 1

The new deal for gig workers

CHAPTER 1

Why this playbook exists

India's gig economy is no longer a side story. NITI Aayog estimated 7.7 million gig and platform workers in 2020-21 and projected 2.35 crore by 2029-30. Until recently every one of them — you — was invisible in labour law: no PF, no ESI, no pension, no accident cover, and no legal definition of the work you do.

That changed in stages. In Budget 2025-26 the government announced three things for platform workers: registration on e-Shram, an identity card, and health cover under Ayushman Bharat. Then the Code on Social Security, 2020 came into force on 21 November 2025, and the Social Security (Central) Rules, 2026 followed on 8 May 2026. Together they make you a recognised worker with statutory rights, a national ID and a funded welfare system behind you.

India's social security coverage, measured by the ILO, rose from 19% in 2015 to 64.3% in 2025 — and gig and platform workers are a big part of that expansion. But a right on paper is only worth something if you claim it. Most of what you are owed depends on one free action: registering on e-Shram and making sure your platform reports your days correctly. This playbook walks you through both.

The bottom line

You now have a legal identity, a route to health cover and insurance, and a funded welfare pool that platforms pay into. None of it arrives automatically. Registration and a filed income-tax return are what convert the law into money and protection for you.

CHAPTER 2

The law that changed on 21 November 2025

The Code on Social Security, 2020 is one of four labour codes that replaced 29 older laws. It was passed in 2020 but brought into force only on 21 November 2025. For gig and platform workers it is historic for a simple reason: it defines you for the first time.

Before this Code, the law had no word for someone who earns through an app without being an employee. You were classed as an unorganised worker at best, with none of the protections that come with a recognised category. The Code fixes that in three ways.

- **It defines you.** 'Gig worker', 'platform worker' and 'aggregator' are now legal terms with specific meanings. That is what makes targeted welfare schemes possible.
- **It mandates schemes for you.** Section 114 requires the Central Government to frame social security schemes for gig and platform workers covering life and disability cover, accident insurance, health and maternity benefits, old-age protection, and crèche facilities.
- **It makes platforms pay.** Aggregators must contribute to a Social Security Fund that finances those schemes — between 1% and 2% of annual turnover, capped at 5% of what they pay workers. This is money that simply did not exist for you before.

A National Social Security Board, with five representatives of aggregators and five representatives of gig and platform workers, oversees this workforce's welfare. A toll-free helpline — 14434 — was set up to inform workers and to handle registration and grievance issues.

What it does not do (yet)

The Code tells the government to create schemes; it does not create them itself. As of late 2026 the machinery — registration, a fund, a board — is in place, and Ayushman Bharat health cover has been announced for platform workers. But several benefit schemes under Section 114 are still being notified. Treat this as the foundation being poured, not the finished house.

CHAPTER 3

Gig worker, platform worker, aggregator

Three definitions decide what you are owed. Learn them, because schemes are written around these exact words.

Term	What it means	Why it matters to you
Aggregator	A digital intermediary or marketplace that connects a buyer or user of a service with a seller or service provider.	Your platform — Zomato, Swiggy, Uber, Ola, Urban Company — is the aggregator. It carries the legal duties.
Gig worker	A person who performs work or takes part in a work arrangement outside a traditional employer-employee relationship and earns from it.	Covers freelancers and app-based workers broadly.
Platform worker	A person undertaking 'platform work' — work arranged through an online platform, outside a traditional employer-employee relationship.	The specific category the new welfare rules target. A delivery partner, driver or home-service pro is a platform worker.

The practical point: you are not an employee of the platform. That single fact explains almost everything else in this playbook — why your income is taxed as business income, why you have no Form 16, and why the new law had to be written specifically for you. It is also why the platform's obligations to you are defined by the aggregator rules, not by employment law.

CHAPTER 4

What the platforms must now do

The Social Security (Central) Rules, 2026, notified on 8 May 2026, turn the Code's promises into concrete duties on your platform. These are obligations on the aggregator — not on you — but knowing them is how you hold the platform to account.

The platform must…	By when
Register itself on the designated central government portal (e-Shram aggregator module).	Ongoing
Upload details of every gig and platform worker already engaged, via API or electronic mode.	Within 45 days of the rules
Register each new worker on the portal.	In real time or daily
Report every worker exit.	In real time
Update worker details.	Quarterly (or as specified)
Submit provisional social-security contribution.	By 30 June each year
Submit the final audited contribution statement.	By 31 October each year

Miss a contribution deadline and the aggregator owes interest at 1% per month — 12% a year — on the unpaid amount. The obligation reaches beyond the app itself: it also covers associate companies, holding companies, subsidiaries and third parties, so a platform cannot push its duties onto a contractor.

The government has pushed hard on onboarding. In an advisory dated 1 June 2026 the Ministry of Labour & Employment told aggregators to finish onboarding and API integration by 21 June 2026, warning of penalties under the Code for delay. By late June 2026 around 20 aggregators — including Zomato, Swiggy, Blinkit, Uber, Ola, Rapido, Zepto, Amazon, Urban Company and Porter — had registered, alongside roughly 10-12 lakh platform workers.

Why the reporting matters to your wallet

Your eligibility for benefits is judged on the days the platform reports you worked. If a platform under-reports, you can lose the benefit even though you worked. Check your e-Shram UAN and your platform statements against each other — Chapter 6 and Chapter 22 show you how.

CHAPTER 5

The four labour codes, and what else changed

The Code on Social Security is the one that names you, but it arrived as part of a package. On 21 November 2025 all four labour codes came into force together: the Code on Wages, 2019; the Industrial Relations Code, 2020; the Code on Social Security, 2020; and the Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions Code, 2020.

For a gig worker, the Code on Social Security does the heavy lifting. But the wider reform changes the background in ways worth knowing:

- **Universal social security.** Coverage is extended across organised and unorganised work, including gig and platform workers, with a Social Security Fund as a dedicated funding source.
- **Wider EPFO and ESIC reach.** EPFO provisions now apply to establishments with 20 or more employees, and ESIC covers establishments with more than 10, with voluntary options below that.
- **Timely wages and minimum wages** became a statutory right for workers under the Code on Wages.
- **Workers' Re-Skilling Fund** for retrenched workers, and a right to annual health check-ups and appointment letters for employees.

The honest caveat: the codes widen the net, but your specific entitlements as a platform worker still flow mainly from the Social Security Code, the 2026 Rules, and the schemes notified under them. Chapter 2 and Chapter 4 are where your rights actually live. This chapter is the context: you are part of a much larger formalisation of work in India.

PART 2 Do you qualify, and how to register

CHAPTER 6

The 90-day / 120-day rule

This is the single most important rule for whether you get benefits, and the one most workers have never heard of.

Under the 2026 Rules, you qualify for social security benefits if you are at least 16 years old and you worked:

- **at least 90 days in the previous financial year with a single aggregator**, or
- **at least 120 days across multiple aggregators**.

Working on a day counts if you earned anything from the platform that day, however small. If you worked on three apps on the same day, that counts as three days, not one. Eligibility ends when you turn 60, or when you stop being engaged as a gig or platform worker.

Now the honest part. Platform disclosures reported in 2026 suggest the average delivery partner works fewer than 40 days a year — far below the threshold. The rules are designed around full-time, regular workers, so a part-timer who dips in and out, or who spreads a few days across several apps, can miss out even while working hard.

What this means for you

If you work full-time on one platform, keep every statement and make sure the days are reported — you should clear 90 days easily. If you work part-time or across apps, concentrate enough days with one aggregator, or spread across apps so the total crosses 120. Either way, register on e-Shram now so the days can be counted at all. (Source: Social Security (Central) Rules, 2026; Ministry of Labour & Employment.)

CHAPTER 7

e-Shram in plain words

e-Shram is the government's national database of unorganised workers, run by the Ministry of Labour & Employment and launched on 26 August 2021. It is the doorway to almost every benefit in this playbook. Over 31.85 crore unorganised workers are already registered on it.

Question	Answer
What do I get?	A free 12-digit Universal Account Number (UAN) and a downloadable UAN card — your national worker ID.
What does it cost?	Nothing. Registration is completely free. Nobody is allowed to charge you.
Does it expire?	No. The card never expires and needs no renewal.
Who can register?	Any unorganised or platform worker aged 16 or above. No income limit, no education requirement.
What do I need?	Your Aadhaar number and an Aadhaar-linked mobile number. No document upload is needed at a registration centre.

Question	Answer
How do I do it?	Self-register at register.eshram.gov.in, use the e-Shram app, or visit a Common Service Centre (CSC) or State Seva Kendra for assisted, biometric registration.
Help line	Toll-free 14434 (assistance in 9 languages). A second number, 1800 889 6811, is also listed on the portal.

Since 21 October 2024, e-Shram has also worked as a 'One-Stop Solution'. Instead of visiting a dozen websites, you log in once with your UAN and see every scheme you are eligible for, apply for it, and track what you have received. Fifteen central schemes are integrated so far, including Ayushman Bharat, PMSBY, PMJJBY, PM-SYM pension, PM SVANidhi, PMAY housing, and One Nation One Ration Card.

CHAPTER 8

Registering on e-Shram, step by step

This takes about ten minutes and costs nothing. Do it on your phone.

1. Open **register.eshram.gov.in** on your phone, or download the e-Shram app. (You can also walk into any CSC or State Seva Kendra and register free, using biometric authentication if your mobile is not linked to Aadhaar.)
2. Enter your **Aadhaar-linked mobile number** and verify the OTP.
3. Complete **Aadhaar eKYC** — consent to authentication, or use the biometric option at a centre.
4. Fill your **personal details** (name, date of birth, address) and choose your **occupation**. For platform work, pick the option that best matches your daily activity — delivery, driving, or the service you provide.
5. Add your **education, skills and bank account** details (an Aadhaar-seeded account makes benefit transfers smoother).
6. Submit. Your **12-digit UAN is issued immediately**, and you can download your UAN card on the spot or later from DigiLocker.
7. Log back in through the **One-Stop Solution**, tap 'Find Eligible Schemes', and apply for the ones that fit you.

Do this, not that

Register yourself on the official portal, or at a government CSC/Seva Kendra — never through a person or website that charges a fee. e-Shram registration is free, always. If someone asks for money to 'get you registered', it is a scam. Report it on the 14434 helpline.

CHAPTER 9

The aggregator route and your ID card

You do not have to wait for your platform to register you — but the platform's own onboarding now runs alongside yours, and the two are meant to meet.

The Ministry launched a dedicated aggregator module on e-Shram on 12 December 2024. Once a platform registers itself (via aggregator.eshram.gov.in), it receives login credentials and can onboard its workers. The flow is designed so that:

- the platform registers you on e-Shram if you are not already registered, and you receive your UAN;
- the platform links your UAN to its own records, so your benefits stay with you if you switch apps;

- the platform uploads your monthly engagement — days worked and amount paid — on a quarterly basis;
- and when you leave, the platform reports your exit.

The Budget 2025-26 announcement also promised platform workers an identity card. The UAN card from e-Shram is the ID that carries your registration; platforms may print your UAN on any additional card they issue. Because the ID is Aadhaar-linked, your benefits are **portable** — they follow you across platforms and states instead of resetting each time you change app.

Your one-line protection

Always give your platform your correct UAN and PAN. If your UAN is not linked, your days may not be counted; if your PAN is not on file, the platform can deduct tax at a much higher rate (see Chapter 17). Two numbers, both yours, both worth keeping current.

CHAPTER 10

Working across several apps

Most gig workers run two or three apps. That is sensible for income, but it changes how you qualify for benefits and how you file tax. Here is the maths.

For eligibility, the rule is 120 days across multiple aggregators in the previous financial year. Because a day with any app counts — and three apps on one day counts as three days — multi-app work can actually help you cross the threshold faster than you would expect. The trap is the opposite: if you spread a few days thinly and never accumulate, you can still fall short.

If you…	What to do
Work full-time on one app	Keep it simple: stay above 90 days on that one platform and keep your statements.
Split between two apps	Either push your main app past 90, or make sure the combined total passes 120.
Dip in and out seasonally	Register on e-Shram anyway; keep every statement, because the days still count if reported.
Drive for a cab app plus a delivery app	Both are platform work — both count toward the 120-day total.

For tax, all your platform income is one business, not several jobs. You add up the gross from every app, keep one consolidated record, and file one return. Keep each platform's payout statement and its TDS certificate (Form 131) — you will reconcile them together.

One practical warning: chasing a peak-hour incentive on a second app can push you into unsafe riding or longer hours than the extra rupee is worth. Add apps for steady earnings, not for reckless ones.

PART 3

The benefits in your dashboard

CHAPTER 11

Ayushman Bharat — Rs 5 lakh health cover

The biggest single benefit announced for platform workers is health cover under Ayushman Bharat — Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB-PMJAY).

AB-PMJAY gives eligible families a health cover of **Rs 5 lakh per family per year** for secondary and tertiary care hospitalisation, across more than 31,000 empanelled public and private hospitals. It covers hospitalisation — not routine doctor visits or medicines bought at a pharmacy.

Budget 2025-26 announced that platform workers would be brought under this cover, and the Ministry of Labour & Employment asked platform workers to self-register on e-Shram as the first step so they can be considered. The e-Shram portal is now interoperable with PM-JAY, with data mapping and verification in place.

How to claim your place in the queue

There is no separate application for the platform-worker version yet. The path is the one you have already started: be registered on e-Shram with your correct details, and check your One-Stop Solution dashboard under 'Health' for the Ayushman Bharat entry. When it shows an 'Apply' button, complete it. Keep your Aadhaar and mobile details current — a stale address or mobile number is the most common reason benefits do not reach a worker.

CHAPTER 12

Insurance and pension you can join today

You do not have to wait for new schemes. Several low-cost government schemes are already open to unorganised and platform workers, and they are integrated into your e-Shram dashboard. For a few hundred rupees a year, these are among the best deals available to you.

Scheme	What it gives you	Cost / eligibility
PMSBY — accident cover	Rs 2 lakh on accidental death or total permanent disability; Rs 1 lakh for partial permanent disability.	Rs 20 a year. Age 18-70.
PMJJBY — life cover	Rs 2 lakh to your family on death from any cause.	Rs 436 a year. Age 18-50.
PM-SYM — pension	Assured Rs 3,000 a month pension from age 60, plus 50% family pension for your spouse.	Age 18-40, monthly income up to Rs 15,000, not a member of EPFO/ESIC/govt NPS, not an income-tax payer. Contribution Rs 55-200 a month; government pays an equal amount.
APY — pension	Guaranteed pension of Rs 1,000 to Rs 5,000 a month from 60, depending on your contribution.	Age 18-40, not an income-tax payer, with a savings or post-office account.

PMSBY and PMJJBY together cost about **Rs 456 a year** and give your family Rs 2 lakh of accident cover and Rs 2 lakh of life cover. If you ride a two-wheeler in traffic all day, that is the cheapest protection you will ever buy. You can enrol through your bank or the e-Shram One-Stop Solution.

PM-SYM is aimed at lower-income workers and is not available once you pay income tax. If you cross that line, APY or the NPS (Chapter 14) are your pension options.

CHAPTER 13

What you should still buy yourself

Government schemes are a floor, not a ceiling. Two gaps remain that you should close yourself.

1. Health cover beyond the hospital bed

Ayushman Bharat pays for hospitalisation. It does not pay for the medicines you buy monthly, the diagnostics, or the outpatient visits that most families actually spend on. A private health insurance policy — or a top-up over Ayushman — fills that gap. Even a basic family floater of Rs 5-10 lakh costs far less per year than one serious illness.

2. Term life insurance sized to your income

If people depend on your earnings, PMJJBY's Rs 2 lakh is nowhere near enough. A term plan worth 10 to 15 times your annual income is the honest number. Buy it while you are young and healthy — premiums rise steeply with age and medical conditions. For a delivery partner, an accident rider is worth the small extra premium.

> **The order to buy in**
>
> First the near-free government cover (PMSBY, PMJJBY, Ayushman). Then a term plan, because your family's income dies with you. Then health insurance for the everyday medical costs. Never buy insurance bundled with an investment — keep protection and saving separate, always.

CHAPTER 14

Retirement when there is no PF

As a gig worker you have no employer PF, no EPS pension, no gratuity. The pension you live on after 60 is the pension you build yourself. The good news: the National Pension System (NPS) is open to any Indian citizen, including self-employed and platform workers.

Under the All Citizen Model, regulated by PFRDA, you open an NPS account with your PAN and Aadhaar, contribute as little as **Rs 500 a month** (or Rs 6,000 a year), and choose how your money is invested. You can pick an active mix — equity up to 75%, plus corporate bonds and government securities — or let an age-based 'auto choice' glide path do it for you.

At exit (normally at 60, or after 15 years), you can withdraw up to **80% as a lump sum** and must use at least 20% to buy an annuity that pays you a lifelong pension. There is also a market-linked drawdown option — the Retirement Income Scheme — that keeps your corpus invested and pays you regularly up to age 85.

NPS is also tax-efficient: your contributions can qualify for deductions, and charges are capped at 0.30% a year, making it one of the cheapest pension products in the world. Since 1 October 2025, non-government subscribers can even hold multiple schemes under one PRAN.

The point of starting small and early

Rs 500 a month feels trivial; over 25 years at market-linked returns it compounds into a real corpus. The workers who will be comfortable at 60 are not the ones who earned the most — they are the ones who started a pension at 25 instead of 45. (Source: PFRDA, National Pension System — All Citizen Model.)

CHAPTER 15

If you are injured or fall ill on the job

A gig worker has no employer ESI, no paid sick leave, and no salary if the bike is in the workshop or the body is in bed. This is where the low-cost schemes earn their keep.

If you are injured on the job, the layers that protect you are:

- **PMSBY** — Rs 2 lakh for accidental death or total permanent disability, Rs 1 lakh for partial permanent disability. Claim through your bank with the accident and medical records.
- **PMJJBY** — Rs 2 lakh to your family on death from any cause.
- **Ayushman Bharat** — covers hospitalisation up to Rs 5 lakh per family per year.
- **Your vehicle insurance** — personal-accident cover if you have a comprehensive policy with the right add-on.

What to do in the moment: get medical care first; keep the medical report and, for a road accident, the police record or a written complaint; inform your platform so the incident is on record; and then claim from each scheme you are enrolled in. Claims fail most often for one reason — missing paperwork — so keep every receipt and report.

The hard truth is that the Code lists health and maternity benefits for gig workers, but the detailed schemes are still being notified. Until they arrive, your own insurance and a savings buffer are what stand between an injury and a debt trap.

PART 4 Your money and your tax

CHAPTER 16

You are a business, not an employee

Here is the fact that trips up almost every gig worker: the money you earn on a platform is not salary. It is business income.

Your contract with the platform treats you as an independent service provider, not an employee. So your income is taxed under 'Profits and Gains of Business or Profession', not 'Salaries'. That has three consequences you must plan around.

- **No standard deduction, no HRA.** The benefits salaried employees take for granted do not apply to you.
- **No Form 16.** No employer files your return or gives you a salary certificate.
- **You must file the right return yourself.** Not the simple ITR-1 most first-timers use — you need a business-income form (ITR-4 or ITR-3).

The upside is that business income lets you choose **presumptive taxation** under Section 44AD: declare 6% of your digital turnover (8% for cash receipts) as your taxable profit, and the rest is treated as your expenses — no bills, no ledgers, no audit. If at least 95% of your receipts are digital, this is available up to Rs 3 crore turnover.

Do not fall into the 0.1% trap

The most expensive mistake gig workers make is assuming 'tax was already deducted, so I do not need to file'. TDS is only an advance against your real tax bill — and for most gig workers the real bill is lower, which is exactly why you must file to get the money back.

CHAPTER 17

The 0.1% TDS that is really your money

Every payout a platform makes to you passes through tax deducted at source first. Understanding it is how you get it back.

An e-commerce operator like Swiggy, Zomato, Amazon or Ola must deduct TDS at **0.1% of the gross amount** it pays you. This rate was cut from 1% to 0.1% with effect from 1 October 2024. From 1 April 2026 the same deduction sits in the new Income-tax Act, 2025 as Section 393 (it was Section 194-O under the old law) — a new number for the same tax.

Situation	TDS on your payout
Individual/HUF with PAN or Aadhaar on file	0.1% of gross
Individual/HUF, gross under Rs 5 lakh a year, PAN on file	No TDS
PAN not given to the platform	Up to 5%
Some contractor-style arrangements	1% (Section 194C)

Two things follow. First, **always give the platform your PAN** — without it, you can lose up to 5% instead of 0.1%. Second, the 0.1% is only an **advance credit**. It appears in your Form 26AS / AIS

(now Form 168 from tax year 2026-27) against the platform's TAN. You claim it back, or set it against your final liability, when you file your return.

From tax year 2026-27, your TDS certificate (formerly Form 16A) is **Form 131**. Match each platform's TDS against your annual statement, and raise discrepancies with the platform quickly — some platforms only entertain them within 15 days of the certificate.

CHAPTER 18

Filing your return

This is the chapter that turns the tax code in your favour. File correctly and most full-time gig workers pay little or nothing — and get their TDS back.

Step 1 — Work out your income

Total up your gross earnings from every platform. Reconcile them against Form 26AS, your AIS and your bank statements. Remember that your bank credit is lower than your gross earnings because of commissions, charges and TDS — so never treat the bank credit as your gross turnover.

Step 2 — Choose your method

- **Presumptive (Section 44AD):** declare 6% of digital turnover as profit. Simple, no books. Use this if you have no major expenses to claim.
- **Actual expenses:** claim fuel, EMI interest on a vehicle loan, insurance, repairs, depreciation, mobile and data. Better if your real costs are high — but you must keep records and file ITR-3.

Step 3 — Pick the right form

Use…	When
ITR-4 (Sugam)	You use presumptive taxation under 44AD and total income is up to Rs 50 lakh.
ITR-3	You declare actual expenses, or want to carry forward a business loss, or income exceeds Rs 50 lakh.

The new regime makes most gig workers tax-free. For FY 2026-27, under the new tax regime, income up to Rs 4 lakh is nil, and the Section 87A rebate of up to Rs 60,000 means **zero tax on taxable income up to Rs 12 lakh**. If your total tax liability would exceed Rs 10,000 after TDS, you must also pay advance tax in quarterly instalments.

Step 4 — GST: usually not your problem

For platform income, GST on notified services such as food delivery and ride-hailing is paid by the aggregator under Section 9(5) of the GST law — the individual worker does not register or file for that income. You only need your own GST registration if you supply services independently and your turnover crosses Rs 20 lakh (Rs 10 lakh in special-category states).

> **The one date to remember**
>
> For business income, the ITR due date is 31 August. Miss it and you can still file a belated return up to 31 December — but you lose the ability to carry forward a business loss, and you cannot switch to the old tax regime for that year. File on time, every year.

CHAPTER 19

The refund story

If the tax chapters feel abstract, these numbers make them real. In 2026 the platforms began helping their workers file returns — and the refunds were substantial.

Platform	Partners who filed	Refunds claimed	First-time filers
Zomato & Blinkit	Over 2.10 lakh	About Rs 33.6 crore	Around 75%
Swiggy	Over 50,000	About Rs 6.5 crore	More than a third
Valmo (Meesho)	About 10,000	About Rs 2 crore	Nearly 70%

Zomato reported an average refund of about Rs 1,600 per filing partner. Across the industry, the large majority of those who filed had never filed before — which tells you how much money was simply being left unclaimed.

A filed return is worth more than the refund, though. Gig workers have no salary slip or Form 16. Two or three years of filed ITRs become your **income proof** when you apply for a two-wheeler or car loan, a personal loan, a credit card, a rented home, or term insurance. It is also what stops a mismatch between what the platform reported and what you declared from turning into a notice.

The habit to build

File every year, even in a year you earned little or think you owe nothing. It costs you an evening and it pays back in refunds, in credit access, and in peace of mind. (Source: company disclosures reported by CNBC-TV18 and The Times of India, September 2026.)

CHAPTER 20

A worked year: a delivery partner

Numbers make the tax rules click. Here is a full-time delivery partner's year, worked through.

Step	Amount (illustrative)
Gross earnings from all platforms	Rs 3,00,000
TDS already deducted by platforms (0.1%)	Rs 300
Presumptive profit under Section 44AD (6%)	Rs 18,000
Tax under the new regime on Rs 18,000	Nil (below the Rs 4 lakh nil slab)
Refund you can claim by filing	Rs 300

Now scale it up. Suppose the same partner had a strong year and grossed **Rs 6,00,000**. The 6% presumptive profit is Rs 36,000 — still far below the Rs 4 lakh nil slab, so still no tax. TDS at 0.1% is about Rs 600, and filing recovers it.

Even at a turnover of **Rs 15,00,000**, the 6% profit is Rs 90,000, and because the Section 87A rebate wipes out tax on taxable income up to Rs 12 lakh, the partner still owes nothing. The refund is bigger, and the income proof is stronger.

The lesson in one line

Presumptive taxation turns a large turnover into a small taxable profit, and the new-regime rebate turns that small profit into zero tax for most gig workers. Filing is not a cost — it is how you get your own money back. Figures are illustrative; compute yours with your actual numbers.

CHAPTER 21

Fuel, vehicle and the real cost of earning

The number on your app screen is not your profit. Your profit is what is left after the cost of earning it — and that cost is real, whether or not you track it.

Monthly cost item	Typical shape
Fuel	The single biggest cost for a two-wheeler or cab
Vehicle EMI or loan interest	Fixed, whether you work or not
Insurance	Third-party mandatory; comprehensive for real protection
Servicing, tyres, repairs	Lumpy — build a monthly provision for it
Phone and data	Your tools; keep them working
Depreciation	The bike is worth less every month; that is a real cost

This is why your bank credit is always lower than your gross earnings, and why comparing your payout to a salaried friend's salary is misleading.

For tax, you have two routes. Under presumptive 44AD, the 6% deemed profit already stands in for all these expenses — simple, but you cannot also deduct them separately. If your real costs are high, keep receipts and file ITR-3 to claim fuel, EMI interest, insurance, repairs, depreciation, mobile and data against your income. Most full-time delivery partners find presumptive simpler; cab owners with big EMIs often find actual expenses better. Run both on your own numbers once a year and pick the one that leaves you better off.

PART 5 Protect yourself

CHAPTER 22

Your rights on the platform

Registration and tax are only half the story. Every day you also deal with the platform itself — ratings, incentives, deactivation, and disputes over pay. Know what is fair and where to go.

- **Your days must be reported.** Under the 2026 Rules your platform must report your engagement and your exit. If your e-Shram UAN shows fewer days than you actually worked, that is a reporting failure — raise it with the platform, and with the helpline.
- **Your payouts must be transparent.** Platform commissions, charges, penalties and TDS should be itemised on your statements. Keep screenshots and statements; you will need them for tax.
- **Deactivation needs a reason and a route.** If you are blocked without explanation, ask for the specific policy and the appeal process. Use the appeal channel in writing, not just in chat.
- **Grievance goes beyond the app.** The Code requires a structured grievance mechanism, and a toll-free helpline (14434) has been set up for platform workers. A facilitation centre to handle worker grievances is also provided for under the reform.

Keep a simple log

One note on your phone: date, hours worked, earnings, and any deduction you did not understand. It takes a minute a day and it is the evidence you need for a tax refund, a dispute, or a loan application.

CHAPTER 23

Ratings, incentives and the algorithm

You cannot see the algorithm, and you cannot argue with it. What you can do is understand what it rewards and manage the parts you control.

- **Ratings gate your work.** Most platforms allocate orders by a score that includes your rating and acceptance rate. Protecting a high rating is not vanity — it is income.
- **Read incentive fine print.** Targets, zones, time windows and order counts all matter. An incentive you cannot realistically hit is a discount on your own time, not a bonus.
- **Peak hours are a trade.** The surge pay is real, but so is the risk of rushing in traffic. Never let a peak-hour bonus buy your safety.
- **Availability beats hustle.** Being reliably online in the right zone at the right time usually earns more than sprinting erratically.

A note on your data: platforms collect a lot about you. Under India's data-protection law you have rights over your personal data, including the right to access and correct it. That is a young area of law, but it is worth knowing that your data is not the platform's free property.

CHAPTER 24

Scams aimed at gig workers

Because you handle money, documents and daily transactions, you are a target. These are the scams that recur.

The scam	The tell	What to do
Paid 'e-Shram registration'	Someone charges a fee to register you, or offers a 'premium' UAN.	e-Shram is free. Register yourself or at a government CSC. Report on 14434.
Fake job or joining fee	You are asked to pay a deposit or 'registration' fee to start work.	No genuine platform charges you to join. Never pay to get work.
Loan-app trap	A fast loan with hidden charges, and access to your contacts and photos.	Use only RBI-regulated banks and NBFCs. Never grant contact or gallery access to a loan app.
Phishing for OTP or UAN	A call or link asking for your OTP, Aadhaar OTP, UAN or PAN.	No official will ask for an OTP. Disconnect; report on cybercrime.gov.in or 1930.
Fake 'refund' message	A message says your tax refund is blocked and asks you to click and pay.	Check refunds only on the Income Tax e-filing portal. Never pay to receive a refund.

The pattern in every case is the same: someone wants a small payment, a document, or an OTP, and the promise is always urgent. Slow down, verify on the official portal, and talk to a fellow worker before you act.

CHAPTER 25

Women in gig work: safety and rights

More women are entering delivery, cab and home-service work every year. The rights are the same; the safety planning needs to be deliberate.

- **Equal treatment.** Pay, incentives and order allocation should not depend on gender. If you are offered different rates or excluded from certain jobs because you are a woman, that is worth raising — with the platform and, if needed, on the helpline.
- **Safety features, used every shift.** Share your live location with someone you trust, keep the in-app SOS ready, verify the customer and drop point before you set off, and avoid isolated pickups at night where you can.
- **Harassment is not part of the job.** Report it to the platform, keep screenshots, and use the police and the cybercrime helpline (1930) where a crime is involved.
- **Maternity and health.** Maternity benefits are listed in the Code for gig workers, and Ayushman Bharat covers maternity hospitalisation; PMMVY gives cash support to eligible mothers. The detailed gig-worker schemes are still being notified — check your e-Shram dashboard.

A practical rule

Trust your instinct about a customer or a location, and leave. No order is worth a risk you would not take for free. Platforms increasingly build safety tools in — use them on every single shift, not only when something feels wrong.

CHAPTER 26

Safety, health and the long game

Gig work pays you for output, not hours — so the temptation is always to work longer, faster, in worse conditions. The workers who last are the ones who protect the asset that earns: themselves.

- **Ride like your family depends on you — because it does.** A helmet, a serviceable vehicle and working lights are not optional. The government accident cover is a safety net, not a licence to take risks.
- **Insure the vehicle properly.** Third-party cover is mandatory; comprehensive cover with a zero-depreciation add-on protects your earnings from a single bad day.
- **Manage the body.** Long hours on a bike or on your feet mean back, knee and eye strain. Stretch, hydrate, and treat sleep as part of the job.
- **Build a small buffer.** Aim for one month of expenses in a separate account before you spend on anything else. It is what stops a medical bill from becoming a loan at 30%.
- **Think about the exit.** Keep a filed ITR, a clean credit record and a skill you are improving — they are what let you move up, not just keep moving.

The whole playbook in one sentence

Register on e-Shram, keep your UAN and PAN current, claim the near-free insurance and health cover, buy term insurance, start a small pension, and file your income-tax return every year. Do those six things and you are more protected than most workers on any app in India.

PART 6 **Making it work**

CHAPTER 27

Managing money on an irregular income

Gig income does not arrive in equal monthly slices. A good week can be double a bad one, and a bike in the workshop can wipe out a fortnight. Budgeting for a swinging income is a different skill from budgeting for a salary.

The first rule is to budget on your **floor**, not your peak. Estimate the least you reliably earn in a slow week, and build your fixed costs — rent, EMI, school fees, fuel — around that number. Treat anything above the floor as surplus to be split between a buffer and one specific goal.

- **Pay yourself a fixed amount** each week from your total earnings, and let the rest sit in the work account for fuel and repairs.
- **Set aside for tax only if you will owe it.** Most full-time gig workers owe nothing, but keep your statements and TDS certificates either way.
- **Build a buffer to one month of expenses first**, then three. It is the difference between a bad week and a loan.
- **Avoid consumer EMIs and loan apps.** They turn a good month into a permanent payment. India's household debt has been rising — the RBI's Financial Stability Report put it at 47.8% of GDP by December 2025, with personal loans making up about 34% of household debt in FY26. Do not add to that pile for a phone or a lifestyle.

The habit that changes everything

Keep a simple monthly record — gross earned, fuel and vehicle, phone, money set aside, money saved (Appendix E has a template). Workers who track their numbers make better decisions than workers who only remember the good weeks.

CHAPTER 28

Buying or upgrading your work vehicle

Your vehicle is not a possession; it is the machine that earns your income. Buy it like a business asset, not like a treat.

- **Check the total cost of credit, not the EMI.** A low EMI over a long tenure can cost far more in interest than a shorter, slightly higher one. Ask for the total repayment figure in writing.
- **Compare the loan, not just the dealer.** Dealer-arranged finance is convenient but not always cheapest. Compare with your own bank before you sign.
- **Insure it properly.** Third-party cover is mandatory; comprehensive cover with a zero-depreciation add-on is what protects your earnings when the bike goes down.
- **Do the petrol-versus-EV maths on your own route.** An electric two-wheeler costs less per kilometre to run, but weighs more upfront and depends on charging. Run your daily distance and running cost on both before deciding.
- **Think resale.** A well-maintained, popular model holds value better — which matters when you upgrade next.

If you buy on a loan, remember the interest is a business expense you can claim if you file ITR-3 with actual expenses (Chapter 21). Under presumptive 44AD, it is treated as already covered by the 6% deemed profit.

CHAPTER 29

If your platform deactivates you

Deactivation feels like losing a job without a notice period. The way to make it survivable is to have already built the things that do not belong to the platform.

- **Ask for the reason and the appeal route.** Many deactivations are automatic and reversible. Put your request in writing, keep screenshots, and follow the platform's review process.
- **Escalate if it is unfair.** The 14434 helpline exists for platform-worker issues, and the reform provides for a grievance facilitation centre.
- **Your UAN benefits do not die with the app.** Because your ID is Aadhaar-linked and portable, your registration and accrued benefits follow you to another platform.
- **Your income proof does not die either.** A filed ITR is yours, and it is what lets you get credit or a new job even after a platform stops your account.
- **Keep a backup platform.** Being onboarded on a second app before you need it is the simplest insurance against a sudden block.

> **The principle**
> Never let a platform own your identity, your income proof, or your access to work. The new law gives you a portable ID precisely so that no single app can hold your livelihood hostage.

CHAPTER 30

Building a second skill

Gig work is a bridge for many and a career for some. Either way, the worker who is learning something is the worker who gets to choose what comes next.

Your e-Shram registration is not only about benefits. It also links you to the Skill India Digital Hub for training and to the National Career Service for job listings — two doors that most gig workers never open.

- **Use the free training.** Skill India Digital Hub offers courses across trades and services; your UAN is the entry point.
- **Move up, not just along.** Fleet supervision, dark-store and warehouse operations, logistics coordination, driving instruction and EV servicing are natural next steps for an experienced rider or driver.
- **Keep the record clean.** A filed ITR and a good credit history are qualifications in their own right when you apply for a salaried role or a business loan.
- **Protect your body and your time.** The skill you build in your twenties should still be worth something in your forties.

CHAPTER 31

The gig worker's year at a glance

A handful of dates decide whether your year runs smoothly. Put them in your phone calendar now.

When	What
1 April	New financial year begins — start a fresh record of earnings.
15 June / 15 Sep / 15 Dec / 15 Mar	Advance-tax instalments, if your liability will exceed Rs 10,000.
30 June	Platform's provisional social-security contribution deadline.
31 August	ITR due date for business income (non-audit).
31 October	Platform's final audited contribution statement.
31 December	Last date for a belated return for the year.
Any time	Update your e-Shram details when your address, mobile or occupation changes.
On renewal	Vehicle insurance and PMSBY/PMJJBY annual debits.

Miss the 31 August ITR date and you lose the ability to carry forward a business loss and to switch tax regimes for that year — even though you can still file until 31 December. The other dates belong to the platform, but they are worth watching because they are where your benefits are funded.

CHAPTER 32

Working safely through rain, cold and heat

India's weather is a working condition, not an inconvenience. The seasons change how you ride, what you wear, and what you should refuse to do.

- **Monsoon.** Check brakes and tyres before the season; wet roads double braking distance. Avoid waterlogged underpasses and flooded routes. Visibility, not speed, is the limit.
- **Winter.** In the north, smog cuts visibility and harms your lungs — a good mask and lights matter on every early-morning and late-night shift.
- **Summer.** Hydrate before you feel thirsty, carry water, and recognise the early signs of heat exhaustion. Heatstroke is a medical emergency, not something to push through.
- **Always.** A helmet, reflective clothing at night, and a charged phone are your three non-negotiables.

The economics of safety

A rider who takes one extra risk to save five minutes can lose a month of income to an injury. Safe is faster over a year. Every experienced worker knows this; the trick is to act like it on the days it is hardest.

PART 7 The finer points

CHAPTER 33

How the reform reached you: a timeline

Knowing when each piece arrived helps you understand what is settled and what is still coming.

When	What happened
2020	Parliament passes the Code on Social Security, 2020 — the first law to define gig and platform workers.
26 August 2021	e-Shram portal launched by the Ministry of Labour & Employment.
21 October 2024	e-Shram 'One-Stop Solution' launched — one login for many schemes.
12 December 2024	Dedicated aggregator module launched on e-Shram.
1 February 2025	Budget 2025-26 announces e-Shram registration, ID cards and Ayushman cover for platform workers.
21 November 2025	The Code on Social Security comes into force; all four labour codes take effect.
8 May 2026	Social Security (Central) Rules, 2026 notified — the operational duties on aggregators.
21 June 2026	Deadline set for aggregators to complete e-Shram onboarding and API integration.
By late June 2026	Around 20 aggregators and roughly 10-12 lakh platform workers onboarded on e-Shram.
Ongoing	Benefit schemes under Section 114 being notified; Ayushman Bharat rollout for platform workers.

The pattern is worth noticing: the registration and funding machinery came first, and the specific benefit schemes are following. Being registered early is what puts you in line for them.

CHAPTER 34

Maternity, family and the gig worker

Gig work has no paid maternity leave, no creche at the office, and no manager to approve time off. The protections exist, but you have to plan around them yourself.

- **The Code lists maternity and crèche benefits** among the schemes it requires for gig and platform workers. Those detailed schemes are still being notified — check your e-Shram dashboard for updates.
- **Ayushman Bharat covers maternity hospitalisation** up to the family limit, which removes the single biggest cost of a delivery.
- **PMMVY** (Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana) gives cash support to eligible mothers for their first living child, paid in instalments through the bank.
- **Plan for the income gap.** Because there is no paid leave, the buffer you build in Chapter 27 is what covers the weeks you cannot ride.
- **Use the flexibility you do have.** Shift timing and platform choice are yours to control — build a routine around care responsibilities instead of fighting it.

CHAPTER 35

Working with customers

You meet more strangers in a week than most people meet in a month, and each interaction can move your rating. Handling disputes well is a skill that pays.

- **Stay calm and professional.** A rating is income. The customer is usually not angry at you — they are angry at a delay or an order.
- **Safety ends the conversation.** If a customer is abusive, threatening or inebriated, do not argue. Leave if you can, report it on the app, and use the police and the 1930 cyber helpline where a crime is involved.
- **Document anything that goes wrong.** A wrong address, a damaged item or a cancelled order is easier to resolve with a photo and a note than with an argument.
- **Follow the process, not your temper.** Platforms have cancellation and dispute flows; use them and keep the reference numbers.

CHAPTER 36

Keeping records the easy way

Gig workers lose money they are owed because they cannot prove what happened. A simple filing habit fixes that.

- **Keep the key documents:** monthly payout statements, Form 131 (TDS certificate), your filed ITR, insurance receipts, vehicle papers, and any medical or accident reports.
- **One place, digital and physical.** A cloud folder plus one paper folder is enough. Photograph paper receipts the day you get them.
- **Keep it for at least six years.** That is how long tax records may be needed.
- **Why it matters:** records are what turn a refund claim, a dispute, a loan application or an insurance claim from a fight into a formality.

> **Five minutes a week**
> Sort your week's screenshots and receipts into the folder every Sunday. It is the cheapest insurance against losing money you are owed.

APPEND IX A

The 30-day action plan

Turn this playbook into a month of small steps. Tick each one off.

Week	Do this
Week 1	Register on e-Shram (or log in and update your details). Note your 12-digit UAN. Confirm your Aadhaar-linked mobile and bank account are current.
Week 2	Check your platform: is your UAN and PAN on file? Start a simple daily log of hours, earnings and deductions. Save last year's statements.
Week 3	On the e-Shram One-Stop Solution, apply for PMSBY (Rs 20) and PMJJBY (Rs 436). Check your Ayushman Bharat status under 'Health'. Start a monthly pension — PM-SYM, APY or NPS.
Week 4	Reconcile earnings with Form 26AS / AIS. Choose 44AD or actual expenses. File or plan your ITR. Get a term-insurance quote. Open a buffer savings account.

APPEND IX B

One-page quick card

What	Where / how
e-Shram self-registration	register.eshram.gov.in — free
Worker helpline	14434 (9 languages)
Ayushman Bharat cover	Rs 5 lakh per family per year
Accident cover	PMSBY — Rs 20/year, Rs 2 lakh
Life cover	PMJJBY — Rs 436/year, Rs 2 lakh
Pension	PM-SYM / APY / NPS (PFRDA)
TDS on payouts	0.1% (Section 194-O / new s.393)
Tax return for business income	ITR-4 (44AD) or ITR-3; due 31 August
Zero tax ceiling (new regime)	Taxable income up to Rs 12 lakh
GST on platform income	Paid by the platform (Section 9(5))
Grievance	Platform appeal + helpline 14434

APPEND IX C

20 questions gig workers ask

Question	Answer
Do I have to register on e-Shram?	It is voluntary, but it is the route to every benefit. Register free on the portal or at a CSC.
Does e-Shram cost anything?	No. Registration is free. Anyone charging a fee is scamming you.
What is my UAN?	A free 12-digit Universal Account Number issued when you register on e-Shram.

Question	Answer
I work on three apps. How do I qualify?	You need 120 days across multiple aggregators in the previous financial year.
I only work part-time. Do I qualify?	Only if you cross 90 days with one app or 120 across apps. Keep every statement.
Am I an employee of the platform?	No. You are an independent service provider, which is why your tax is business income.
Why is my payout lower than my gross?	Platform commission, charges, penalties and TDS are deducted before you are paid.
What is the 0.1% deduction?	TDS under Section 194-O (now Section 393). It is advance tax you can claim back.
Do I need to file an ITR?	Yes, if you have business income above the basic exemption. Filing also recovers your TDS.
Which form do I file?	ITR-4 if you use presumptive 44AD; ITR-3 if you claim actual expenses or carry forward a loss.
What is Section 44AD?	A presumptive rule letting you declare 6% of digital turnover as profit, with no books.
Will I owe tax?	Most full-time gig workers owe nothing, because of the 44AD profit and the Rs 12 lakh rebate.
Do I need GST registration?	Generally no for platform income — the platform pays GST under Section 9(5).
What is Ayushman Bharat for me?	Rs 5 lakh a year family health cover for hospitalisation, announced for platform workers.
Is PMSBY worth it?	Yes. Rs 20 a year for Rs 2 lakh of accident cover is the cheapest protection you can buy.
How do I save for retirement?	PM-SYM or APY if you do not pay tax; NPS if you do. Start small and early.
What if the platform deactivates me?	Ask for the reason and use the appeal channel; escalate to the 14434 helpline if needed.
What if I am injured on the job?	Claim PMSBY for accident, Ayushman for hospitalisation; keep all medical records.
Someone offered to register me for a fee. Real?	No. It is a scam. Register free yourself and report on 14434.
How long should I keep records?	Keep statements, Form 131 and your ITR for at least six years.
Can I claim fuel and repairs as expenses?	Yes, if you file ITR-3 with actual expenses. Under 44AD they are deemed covered by the 6%.
What if I earn in cash?	Cash receipts are taxed at an 8% deemed profit under 44AD instead of 6% for digital.
Do I need to keep a vehicle log?	It helps if you claim actual expenses, and it strengthens any insurance claim.
Is e-Shram the same as my UAN for EPF?	No. e-Shram issues a 12-digit UAN for unorganised workers; it is separate from an EPF UAN.

Question	Answer
Will registering stop me getting other benefits?	No. It is the gateway to benefits, not a restriction on them.
What if my platform does not report my days?	Raise it with the platform in writing and escalate on the 14434 helpline.
Do I have to pay advance tax?	Only if your tax liability after TDS will exceed Rs 10,000 for the year.
Can a platform force me to be an employee instead?	Classification follows your contract and working reality, not a label. Get advice if it matters.
Where do I complain about a scheme not reaching me?	Your e-Shram dashboard, the 14434 helpline, or the relevant ministry portal.
What is the single most important thing to do first?	Register on e-Shram, and make sure your PAN is on file with every platform.

APPEND IX D A worked 44AD calculation

How presumptive profit is computed at different turnover levels (illustrative).

Gross digital turnover	Profit at 6% (44AD)	Tax under new regime
Rs 3,00,000	Rs 18,000	Nil
Rs 6,00,000	Rs 36,000	Nil
Rs 9,00,000	Rs 54,000	Nil
Rs 12,00,000	Rs 72,000	Nil
Rs 15,00,000	Rs 90,000	Nil (rebate covers up to Rs 12 lakh)

APPEND IX E Monthly money tracker

Copy this into a notebook or a spreadsheet and fill it every month.

Month	Gross earned	Fuel + vehicle	Phone/data	Set aside for tax	Saved

APPEND IX F Glossary

Term	Meaning
Aggregator	The digital platform that connects customers to service providers.

Term	Meaning
Gig worker	Someone who works outside a traditional employer-employee relationship and earns from it.
Platform worker	A gig worker whose work is arranged through an online platform.
UAN	Universal Account Number — your 12-digit e-Shram worker ID.
AB-PMJAY	Ayushman Bharat — Rs 5 lakh family health cover.
PMSBY / PMJJBY	Low-cost accident and life insurance schemes.
PM-SYM / APY / NPS	Pension schemes for self-employed and unorganised workers.
TDS	Tax Deducted at Source — advance tax, refundable when you file.
44AD	Presumptive tax rule: declare 6% of digital turnover as profit.
ITR-4 / ITR-3	Income-tax return forms for business income.

APPEND IX F2

The four labour codes at a glance

Code	What it covers	Relevance to you
Code on Wages, 2019	Minimum wages and timely payment.	Sets the floor for how work should be paid.
Industrial Relations Code, 2020	Employer-worker relations, disputes, unions.	Background context; gig workers are not classic employees.
Code on Social Security, 2020	PF, ESI, gratuity, and social security for all workers.	The law that defines you and funds your benefits.
Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions Code, 2020	Workplace safety, health, working conditions.	Sets the safety expectations the reform builds on.

APPEND IX F3

A sample month, worked

An illustrative month for a full-time two-wheeler delivery partner, so the numbers are concrete.

Item	Amount
Gross earnings (all platforms)	Rs 26,000
Less: fuel	Rs 4,500
Less: phone and data	Rs 400
Less: vehicle provision (service, tyres, insurance)	Rs 1,800
Less: set aside for buffer	Rs 2,000
Available for the household	Rs 17,300

APPEND IX F4

How to read your payout statement

A typical platform statement has four moving parts. Learn them and you will spot errors in seconds.

Line on the statement	What it means
Gross earnings	The full value of the work before any deduction.
Platform commission / charges	The platform's cut and any service or penalty charges.
TDS (0.1%)	Advance tax deducted under Section 194-O / Section 393 — recoverable when you file.
Net payout	What actually reaches your bank. It is always lower than gross earnings.

APPEND IX G

Sources & verification

Every factual claim in this playbook was checked against the following primary and official sources in October 2026.

- Code on Social Security, 2020 (in force 21 November 2025) — Ministry of Labour & Employment; PIB; Lok Sabha answers.
- Social Security (Central) Rules, 2026 (notified 8 May 2026) — Ministry of Labour & Employment.
- e-Shram portal and FAQs; e-Shram aggregator onboarding advisory (1 June 2026) — eshram.gov.in; labour.gov.in.
- Press Information Bureau releases on gig and platform workers' social security (2025-26).
- Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY; PMSBY, PMJJBY, PM-SYM — Ministry of Labour & Employment; PIB.
- National Pension System — All Citizen Model — PFRDA; Department of Financial Services.
- Income Tax Department — TDS (Section 194-O / Section 393), Section 44AD, Section 87A rebate, FY 2026-27 slabs; CBIC for GST (Section 9(5)).
- NITI Aayog, 'India's Booming Gig and Platform Economy'; ILO social-protection data via PIB.
- Company disclosures on ITR filing and refunds — Zomato/Blinkit, Swiggy, Valmo — reported September 2026.

A final word

The rules that protect you are only as good as your awareness of them. Register, keep your records, claim what is yours, and pass this on to a fellow worker who does not know. That is how a law on paper becomes money in hand.